PLACE Making Team Aboriculture

Development Management Consultation Response

Date: 27 June 2024

Reference:	Site:	Proposal:	Case Officer:
S/RES/24/0551	Land North Of A420 Eastern Villages Swindon	Reserved Matters application (following planning application S/OUT/13/1555) for details of the layout, scale, appearance, access and landscaping in relation to a foul water pumping station. The outline planning application was subject to and submitted with an Environmental Impact Assessment.	Ed Snook
Summary of response			
		No Comment/No Objection	☐
		Conditions required	☐
		Objection - changes required	☒
		Objection in principle	☐
Executive Summary			

Full Comments

The application for the construction of a foul water pumping station is accompanied by an arboricultural assessment (dated May 2024) and a landscape plan (ref 1796-L-120), both prepared by FPCR. The siting of the pumping station footprint is within the field and doesn't directly affect the primary vegetation but the creation of the access to it will result in the loss of a section of the existing boundary hedge and a mature Oak protected by a tree preservation order.

The character of Old Vicarage Lane is defined by mature hedgerows and trees along its length from the junction with the A420 up to South Marston village. The removal of a 67m section of the hedgerow (H33) will have an immediate adverse impact on the amenity afforded to users of Old Vicarage Lane. The hedgerow is assessed as low quality, primarily due to its lack of recent maintenance, but could readily be improved with appropriate management practices. The arboricultural assessment notes, at 5.17, that a new hedgerow will be replanted set back to the south west of the original hedge line as mitigation for its loss. Whilst there would be a delay in attaining the visual prominence of the hedge it is replacing, a new hedgerow would ultimately provide a continuity of character along the lane.

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The loss of the mature Oak (T57) is much less easily mitigated and the statement at 6.1 that new tree planting as a component of the proposed landscaping for the wider development will more than mitigate the losses required for the pumping station proposals overlooks the fact that comprehensive planting is explicitly required to assimilate the new development within the landscape, not as a direct replacement for individual trees. The Oak is positioned outside the application boundary, but the construction of the proposed access breaches the tree's root protection area (RPA) and the subsequent root severance would immediately lead to stability issues. If the access were to be relocated outside the RPA, the retention of the tree could then be considered against the requirements for sight lines. The S.278 works plan (Brookbanks 1335-S278-OVL-SK-132 rev A) shows the position of the tree beyond the sight lines of the current junction arrangement (as below), the achievement of which should be the starting point for repositioning of the access.

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The landscape plan appears to show the boundary treatment with Old Vicarage Lane as being grassland, rather than a new hedgerow being set back to the southwest of the existing location, that is stated as direct mitigation in the arboricultural assessment at 5.7. Clarification on that issue is required.

The pumping station itself receives the screening benefit of a linear native woodland edge planting to the east and west sides, with a native species rich hedgerow being established on its northern boundary. Southern boundary screening is reliant on the existing self-seeded group of trees (G76) on the railway embankment. This is outside the site and, therefore, outside the control of the applicant. Its future management will be under the control of Network Rail who advise that they routinely clear vegetation from the area immediately next to the track or further back on embankments. There is a high likelihood that the vegetation will be removed and consideration will need to be given as to whether the embankment itself affords sufficient screening or whether the southern boundary requires the establishment of suitable screening within the site.